



CHINA

Capital city: Beijing**Area:** 3,705,386 sq miles
(9,596,960 sq km)**Population:** 1,300,000,000**Official language:**
Mandarin**Major religions:**
Traditional religions
20%, Buddhist 6%,
Muslim 2%, other 72%**Government:** One-party
state**Currency:** Yuan**Adult literacy rate:** 91%**Life expectancy:** 71 years**People per doctor:** 714**Televisions:** 272 per
1,000 people

CHINA

ONE IN EVERY FIVE PEOPLE in the world live in just one country – China. This vast country is almost the same size as Europe. It is the third largest country in the world after Russia and Canada. It has also one of the world's oldest civilizations, with a history stretching back more than 7,000 years. Ruled by a succession of emperors, China became a republic in 1911 and a communist state in 1949. Under the communists, every aspect of life is controlled by the state and China has become a major industrial and military power. In recent years it has begun to move toward a more competitive economy that encourages investment from other countries.

The art of handwriting, or calligraphy, is highly prized in China because great care is required to draw each character correctly.



CHINESE WRITING

Unlike English or French, which use an alphabet of 26 letters, Chinese writing uses more than 50,000 characters, or symbols. Each character depicts a different word or idea. Simple words, such as "sky," or "rain," use one character. Complex words use two or more – "telephone" uses the characters for "electric" and for "talk."

RICE GROWING

Two-thirds of China's large population lives and works on the land. The most fertile areas are found in the south. The main crop is rice, though tea, cotton, fruit, and vegetables are also grown. The rice is planted in flooded paddy fields (shown below). Two crops of rice and one of vegetables or cereal grains are harvested in a good year. In the north and west of the country, which is drier and hillier, farmers grow a single crop of cereal grains and tend sheep and cattle.

Sowing



While the paddy fields are being prepared, rice seeds are sown in a separate flooded field, or seedbed.



After a month, the tightly packed rice shoots are ready for transplanting into the paddy fields.

Plowing

Water buffaloes are used to plow, rake, and flatten the muddy paddy fields, ready for planting.



Some farms in China have tractors, but most use water buffaloes or oxen.

Low earth barriers known as bunds separate the paddy fields.

Planting

Women do the back-breaking work of planting the rice shoots.

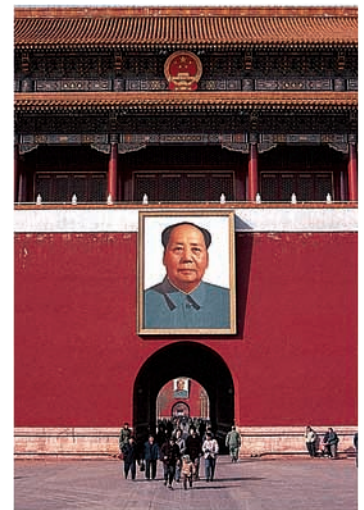


Water in the paddy fields keeps down weeds.



THE FORBIDDEN CITY

When the emperor Zhu Di rebuilt China's capital, Beijing, in the 15th century, he created a vast imperial palace in the center of the city. The palace became known as the Forbidden City because only the emperor's family and closest advisers could enter it. Encircled by walls, it contains nearly 1,000 buildings, including temples, stables, and a library.



Portraits of Mao Zedong still hang in Tiananmen Square in Beijing, the largest public square in the world.